

EAST ASIAN SWORDS

The earliest Chinese swords were straight and double-edged, but single-edged swords date at least as far back as the late Han dynasty (206BCE–220CE), their blade shape evolving into a variety of forms. At first, the Japanese imported swords from China, but by 1000CE, they had perfected their own style of the single-edged, curved blade that did not materially change for the next 1,000 years. Japanese blades were designed to be removable from the rest of the sword, enabling the same blade to be worn for generations, becoming an heirloom within a family. The blades were reset in new mounts, consisting of the *tsuka* (hilt or grip), *tsuba* (hand guard), and *saya* (scabbard). Some swords, particularly short swords and daggers, had pockets in the scabbard for a *kozuka* (a small knife) and a *kogai*, a skewer-like implement for dressing the hair.

► DAO

Date	17th century
Origin	China
Weight	520g (18¼oz)
Length	64cm (25in)

This short, single-edged sword or *dao* has a near-straight *yanmaodao* (goose quill) blade. Primarily a cavalry weapon, its single edge was used for cutting and its point for thrusting.

Gold *menuki* (ornamentation) under criss-crossed silk braid to improve grip



▲ WAKIZASHI

Date	c.1640
Origin	Japan
Weight	480g (17oz)
Length	53.4cm (21in)

The samurai wore the *wakizashi* (short sword) as an accompaniment to the *katana*. It was also the only sword permitted to be worn by other social groups.



Disc-shaped hand guard

Kogai or tool for dressing the hair



SCABBARD

Shinogi-ji or the area above ridge

WAKIZASHI



Nakago or tang

Hole for a peg that held the blade in the hilt



KATANA BLADE

Tsuka (wooden hilt) wrapped in rayskin under silk braid

Tsuba (hand guard) of iron or soft metal



Sageo (heavy silk braid) tied the sword into the belt



BLADE IN MOUNT

Koi guchi or the mouth of the scabbard

Eyelet for (missing) tassel

Wooden hilt bound with cord for grip

Fretted and carved hand guard



▲ EDO PERIOD KATANA BLADE AND MOUNT

Date	17th century
Origin	Japan
Weight	1.3kg (2¾lb)
Length	1.06m (3½ft)

During the 16th century, samurai began to wear an *uchiganata* (striking sword) thrust edge upwards through their belt; it was easier to draw than the earlier slung *tachi* (long sword). This style of sword came to be known as *katana*, and could only be worn by the samurai class.

▲ KATANA BLADE

Date	15th century
Origin	Japan
Weight	630g (22¼oz)
Length	87cm (34¼in)

This *katana* blade has been removed from its mountings. It was secured into the wooden hilt by the taper of the tang, and by a bamboo peg, which passed through the hole in the tang and corresponding holes in the hilt.



Tang